

THE NOOSE TIGHTENS



The sensational *Tehelka* sting exposes the ugly faces behind the 2002 riots and comes closer to proving that the state administration, including CM Narendra Modi, were actively involved

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Just as Indira Gandhi could never disassociate herself from the Emergency, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi finds it impossible to extricate himself from the infamous 2002 riots in Gujarat that claimed around 1,300 lives, nearly 1,000 of them being Muslims. The carnage returned to haunt Modi once again as *Tehelka* magazine, in a stunning sting operation, caught on camera VIP activists, actual perpetrators of the crimes as well as government counsel boasting how the anti-Muslim riots, in the aftermath of the Godhra killings, were carried out in a planned manner with the support of Modi, and how the judicial process was circumvented, with the connivance of the state Government, to provide an escape route to the accused.

The sting operation was carried out over six months with the reporter posing as an author writing a book from the Hindutva point of view. VIP activists described on camera the gory acts they committed, including rape and cold-blooded slaughter. Modi, typically, has chosen to dismiss the allegations but the focus is now on the judicial implications of the exposé especially after a lower court judgement, a week after the sting was aired, on the Eral case, one of the prominent riots cases of 2002 in which nine Muslims were killed by a Hindu mob, including two women who were raped and then killed. The Godhra District Court sentenced eight to life imprisonment and three others to lesser terms. As a jubilant human rights activist Teesta Setalvad, who is fighting the Gujarat riot cases in the Supreme Court and aims to involve Modi himself, commented after the sting operation, "Every such episode renews our hope that justice will be done to the riot victims. The *Tehelka* exposé should be admitted as substantive evidence by the Supreme Court."

TRAPPED: Modi brushes aside the revelations but the evidence points to his active connivance

The new sting operation is further proof that the state Government was involved in the riots and had shielded the guilty. The electoral impact is unclear but the judicial process has been given a wake up call.



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